



Sri Lanka



The teardrop-shaped island of Sri Lanka is separated from India by the Palk Strait. Ethnic Tamil rebels – the Tamil Tigers – were defeated in 2009, after a brutal 26-year civil war.



GEOGRAPHY

The main island is dominated by rugged central highlands. Fertile northern plains are dissected by rivers. Much of the land is tropical jungle.



CLIMATE

Tropical, with breezes on the coast and cooler air in highlands. Northeast is driest and hottest.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Sinhalese are mostly Buddhist, while Tamils are mostly Hindu. Moors are the Muslim descendants of Arab traders. Tamils were the minority group favored by the British colonists. Majority-Sinhalese power since independence in 1948 fueled tensions, erupting into civil war in 1983. The eventual government victory in 2009 made this the only rebel insurgency ever defeated in modern times.



THE ECONOMY

Garment industry. Remittances. Major tea exporter. Civil war drained government funds, deterred investors and tourists. Tsunami damage in 2004.



INSIGHT: Sri Lanka elected the world's first woman prime minister, Sirimavo Bandaranaike, in 1960



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic Socialist Republic of Sri Lanka

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Colombo

POPULATION: 20.2 million

TOTAL AREA: 25,332 sq. miles
(65,610 sq. km)

DENSITY: 810 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Sinhala*, Tamil*, English

RELIGIONS: Buddhist 69%, Hindu 15%, Muslim 8%, Christian 8%

ETHNIC MIX: Sinhalese 82%, Tamil 9%, Moor 8%, other 1%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Sri Lanka rupee = 100 cents